Ergative Anaphors and High Absolutive Syntax

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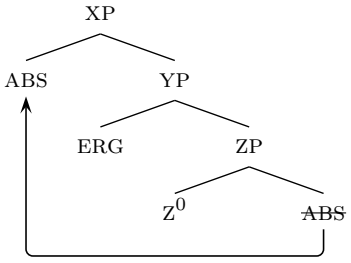
Many morphologically ergative languages show an asymmetry in the Ā-domain: certain types of Ā-extraction can target the absolutive argument but not the ergative. This restriction reflects one of the patterns classically grouped together under the term 'Syntactic Ergativity' (Dixon, 1994). Following Aissen (2017), we refer to it as the Ergative Extraction Constraint (EEC).

The standard analysis of the EEC links it to locality constraints in the Ā-domain (Rizzi, 1990; Campana, 1992). On this view, the ban on ergative extraction arises from the restriction that Ā-extraction must target the highest argument in the clause. In nominative-accusative languages, such a constraint often rules out the extraction of accusative arguments (Shlonsky, 1992). In a subset of ergative languages, the same constraint delivers the EEC (Bittner, 1994; Aldridge, 2004; Coon et al., 2014). We refer to this approach as the locality analysis of syntactic ergativity and restate it in (1).

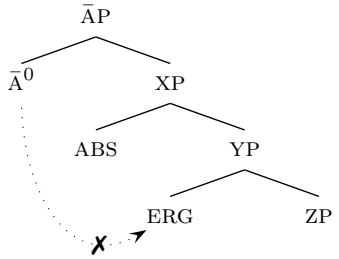
(1) *The Locality Analysis*
The EEC reflects a locality constraint: extraction targets the highest argument in the clause.

The locality analysis makes a specific structural prediction about the constructions which show the EEC. On this view, these constructions invariably show *High Absolutive* syntax (2): they involve a step of movement which places the absolutive argument in a position above the ergative. This process yields a configuration in which ergative extraction is blocked for reasons of locality (3).

(2) *High Absolutive Syntax*



(3) *Locality of Extraction*



The success of the locality analysis rests on the strength of evidence for High Absolutive syntax in the languages which show the EEC. In many cases, this evidence is robust and well-established (Guilfoyle, Hung & Travis, 1992; Bittner, 1994). Nevertheless, it is often of a rather delicate type: it typically rests on patterns of binding and coreference which can show language-specific variation. As such, the arguments for and against (2)- and thus the locality analysis- must be made with care.

This paper addresses one common argument against the locality analysis and shows that it does not go through. The argument concerns the distribution of reflexive anaphors. In many languages, these elements cannot be ergative arguments (Anderson, 1976). We restate this fact in (4) below.

(4) *The Ban on Ergative Anaphors*
In many ergative languages, reflexive anaphors cannot surface as external arguments.

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The literature has repeatedly taken the pattern in (4) to provide evidence against the existence of High Absolutive syntax in a range of unrelated languages (Bobaljik & Branigan, 2006; Legate, 2006; Massam, 2006; Otsuka, 2006). The logic of this argument runs as follows: (*i*) if the distribution of reflexive anaphors is governed by nothing beyond the requirement for a clause-internal antecedent, then (*ii*) an ergative anaphor should be able to be bound by an absolutive argument in a construction which shows High Absolutive syntax. On these assumptions, the absence of ergative anaphors in a given construction may suggest the absence of High Absolutive syntax- and may therefore necessitate an analysis of the EEC which makes no reference to locality (Otsuka, 2006; Deal, 2017).

We object to this analysis on two counts. First, reflexive anaphors are notoriously subject to constraints on their distribution which go far beyond the simple requirement for a clause-internal antecedent (Chomsky, 1986; Ahn, 2015; Ershova, 2019). Second, anaphor binding facts run against other diagnostics for hierarchical asymmetries between arguments in a range of High-Absolutive languages. These facts show that the absence of ergative anaphors does not provide an argument against the presence of High Absolutive syntax. We restate these two points in (5) below.

(5) *The Ergative Anaphor Generalization*

a. The ban of ergative anaphors arises from independent constraints on anaphor binding.

b. It cannot be interpreted as an argument against the existence of High Absolutive syntax.

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. In Section _, we highlight the absence of ergative anaphors in two unrelated ergative languages: Chuj (Q'anjob'alan, Mayan) and Mandar (South Sulawesi, Austronesian). In Sections _-_, we show that both of these languages show High Absolutive syntax. In Section _, we show that the same situation recurs in Austronesian and Inuit: languages which show robust evidence for High Absolutive syntax regularly lack ergative anaphors. In Section _, we conclude that the ban of ergative anaphors does not provide evidence against High Absolutive syntax and must be attributed to independent constraints.

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